



round-robin system with promotion and relegation. The women's league of the Olympic champion Netherlands mirrors their men's league, with its first season dating back to 1981.

In comparison, India doesn't offer a professional league system. The recent Senior Nationals lasted just 13 days. The upcoming HIL, similar to the 2013-17 version, will see each team play 10 league games, followed by the knockouts in the men's league. In the W-HIL, each team will play six pool fixtures.

Germany's Pasha Gademan, who will coach the Hyderabad Toofans, felt India did not have to replicate the European model while pointing out that the infrastructure is built for a shorter league.

"I doubt, in this setup [it's possible]. I would say that the two things are very different. I think calling it a league is interesting because it sounds more like a 'Hockey India tournament,' but 'league' sounds a lot better, so I support the name. But it's a bit more

of a tournament, and the league in Europe is stretched out over a very long period," said Gademan, who was the assistant coach for the German men's national team during the 2023 World Cup win.

He added, "I'd rather see it stay like a compact league and have a high boost or an exciting period in the year instead of a regular league because a regular league has its pros and cons. I've been a coach of a top team for the last four seasons in Germany, yet the first 20 matches are almost boring in the sense that we know we're going to win everything until the very end. And so you've got three quarters of a year where it's not that exciting, and the last quarter of the year is super exciting."

Top Europeans pull out

The scheduling issue, while not a roadblock, continues to be a thorn for HIL, leading to several overseas stars pulling out. The HIL was provided with a window by the International Hockey Federation from December 28 till the first week of February.

Past imperfect: When the HIL initially folded in 2017, it was mired in issues, with teams facing financial burdens resulting in salary defaults for players and staff, and scheduling conflicts with the international calendar being the primary ones. GETTY IMAGES

As many as 29 players from both the men's and women's leagues withdrew after the auction. Top European names like Seve Van Ass (UP Rudras), Tom Boon (Team Gonasika), Christopher Ruhr (Delhi SG Pipers), Tom Grambusch (Rarh Bengal Tigers), Jean-Paul Danneberg (Hyderabad Toofans), Nike Lorenz and Anna Toman (Soorma Hockey Club), etc., are giving the tournament a miss this year.

Reduced salaries, injuries and scheduling are among the prime factors cited for the withdrawals. While the competition offers a hefty payday for a short duration, the HIL falls during what would typically be their winter break from domestic leagues back home.